



IMPERIAL POLICING

A local soldier stands guard in front of an RAF Hawker Hardy in northern Iraq in the 1930s. British aircraft were sent to Iraq to protect the Kirkuk oilfields and pipelines from hostile tribes, a cheaper option than sending imperial troops.

comforting symbol of the dominance of the “civilized” peoples over the “uncivilized.” Not surprisingly, air power appealed especially to the militaristic right-wing nationalist movements that came to power in much of Europe between the wars, for which Italian dictator Benito Mussolini’s Fascists established the pattern.

When Mussolini’s black-shirted followers bullied their way to power in 1922, several Italian World War I air aces were prominent in their ranks. Mussolini himself idolized aviation, revering it as a symbol of power and modernity. “Not every Italian can or should fly,” he declared, “but all Italians should envy those who do and should follow with profound feeling the development of Italian wings.”

In 1923, an independent Italian air force was created, the Regia Aeronautica, and the scale of Italy’s air power rapidly expanded. Mussolini’s dictatorship gloried in the incredible stunts that drew world attention to Italian aviation, from the individual achievement of naval officer Francesco de Pinedo’s flight from Rome to Tokyo in 1925, to the mass flying-boat spectacles staged by Italo Balbo between 1928 and 1933. The Italian air force got to carry out its own colonial campaign against rebels in the deserts of Libya and, in 1935, was used against the forces of Emperor Haile Selassie when Italy invaded the independent African state of Ethiopia.

German rebirth

Germany was another country where no questions were raised about the importance of air power. Formally denied the right to maintain an army or naval air force by the terms of the Treaty of Versailles, throughout the 1920s German military leaders, aviators, and aircraft makers worked, often covertly, to maintain pilot training and keep up with advances in military aviation technology and tactics. This was partly achieved through the development of German civil aviation, in which former World War I air commanders and pilots

WINGS OVER CHICAGO

ON THE EVENING OF JULY 15, 1933, a mass formation of 24 Italian Savoia-Marchetti S.55X flying boats, commanded by General Italo Balbo, flew over Lake Michigan toward Chicago after a 15-day, 5,750-mile (9,200-km) transatlantic flight from Orbetello, Italy, via Iceland.

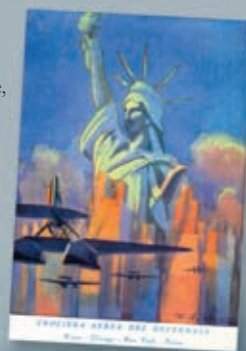
That month Chicago’s population was swollen with visitors to the Century of Progress World’s Fair, staged to celebrate the city’s first centenary. Hundreds of thousands of spectators lined the lakefront for the arrival of the Italian squadron. In perfect formation, three by three, the twin-hulled Savoia-Marchettis circled over the city and then descended gracefully onto the lake, while an escort of 43 American fighter aircraft spelled out the word “Italy” in the sky.

Balbo received a hero’s welcome, and was fêted with celebratory dinners and parades – he even had a major avenue named after him. The Chicago flight was a sensational propaganda coup for the Italian Fascist dictatorship, helping to project an international image of an efficient and technologically advanced regime.



RECORD-BREAKING FLYING BOATS

Originally designed in 1925 as a torpedo-bomber, the huge 79ft- (24m-) wingspan Savoia-Marchetti S.55 was later adapted for passenger service. Identified by its back-to-back engines above the wing, it broke 14 flying-boat records for speed, altitude, distance, and load-carrying.



TRANSATLANTIC TRIUMPH

This postcard, commemorating the 50th anniversary of Italo Balbo’s transatlantic flight, depicts Savoia-Marchetti S.55 flying boats approaching the New York skyline with the Statue of Liberty looming.

FORMATION FLYING

General Balbo’s S.55 flying boats alight in Jamaica Bay, New York, during their epic 48-hour transatlantic crossing to Chicago. The 24 S.55s completed the entire flight in a tight V formation. Even today, pilots refer to a large formation of aircraft as a “Balbo.”

inevitably played a major role. As director of Luft Hansa from 1925, ex-squadron commander Erhard Milch was in constant contact with top officers in the Reichswehr, ensuring that they were fully informed of the latest navigation techniques and flight instrumentation. Air clubs and flying schools also played their part, acting as a training network for future military pilots under the cover of sports aviation.

A major German military-aviation program took place in the newly established Soviet Union. In 1922, the Germans and Soviets signed the Rapallo Treaty, finding common ground in their status as pariah states in postwar Europe.

Under secret military provisions of the treaty, Germany was allowed to carry out army and air-force training in Russia, in return for providing Soviet forces with training and the latest military technology. A substantial German base was established in Lipetsk, 220 miles (350km) outside Moscow, where, from 1925 to 1933, German pilots were secretly trained to fly state-of-the-art military aircraft, practicing bombing, fighter tactics, and maneuvers.



CIVIL AND MILITARY

Erhard Milch, a World War I fighter pilot, was head of Deutsche Luft Hansa from 1925 until 1933, when he was given the task of rebuilding the Luftwaffe.